

Seven Principles of Adult Learning

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Introduction

Adult learning, often referred to as andragogy, focuses on how adult learners engage with new information in ways that are quite different from younger students. This unique approach is built on five key assumptions: adults usually prefer to take charge of their own learning, they leverage their life experiences as valuable resources, their motivation to learn is closely linked to their personal goals, they tend to concentrate on tasks related to their lives and work, and they possess an intrinsic drive to improve themselves. Along with these important assumptions about adult learning, the research has shown seven basic but powerful principles that help in building strong connections, motivate and encouraging everyone to get involved, and appreciating the unique strengths each person may bring, thus helping adults to learn better in all kinds of environments. To connect and teach adults effectively whether it is online learning or in classrooms, it is very important that we adhere to these assumptions and principles that will addressing real-world problems and guiding them through experiential learning. Building on these principles, this paper delves into seven best practices in adult education, explains why these practices resonate with me as both a learner and an educator, and emphasizes two principles I aim to integrate more thoughtfully into my own courses.

Adult learning and the seven principles

As adults take on new roles in their personal and professional lives, they tend to take more control over their own learning, often drawing on past experiences as valuable guides. They prefer learning that tackles real-life problems and are usually motivated from within themselves (Knowles, 1984). Building on these ideas, Chickering and Gamson identified seven practical principles to improve teaching and learning in any setting. These are: 1) Encourage contact between students and faculty; 2) Develop reciprocity and cooperation among students; 3) Encourage active learning; 4) Give prompt feedback; 5) Emphasize time on task; 6)

Communicate high expectations; and 7) Respect diverse talents and ways of learning (Chickering & Gamson, 1987). Together, these assumptions and principles provide a clear framework: the assumptions explain why adults learn the way they do, while the Seven Principles offer practical guidance on how to design courses and teach effectively every day. This combination brings both purpose and structure to adult education.

Why the seven principles matter to me as a learner and an educator?

Working in a clinical setting, I seek guidance that accounts my time and keeps me on track to focus on real problems. Quick interactions with patients, clinicians and my instructors help me stay on track through complex schedules and about data sources, while working with my team and peers in class turns a project into shared discovery with future perspectives. Active learning is important as it motivates me to think differently and use knowledge to my daily work. Timely feedback helps me correct mistakes early and focus on what really matters. Managing time wisely is key when balancing coursework with professional duties. Clear expectations keep me motivated and signal that the learning matters. Most importantly, valuing different talents improves my experience and opens multiple paths to success.

When I move into the role as an educator, these principles help me how I design learning experiences. I start by explaining the purpose of each learned skill and then link it to real tasks. I organize courses around frequent, low-pressure practice paired with clear feedback from both instructors and peers, helping build confidence through small but steady steps. Teamwork, peer reviews, and teach-back sessions make learning fun and engaging. To help with time management, I use clear rubrics, examples, checklists, and staged deadlines that show progress. I set high expectations while offering guidance to help students succeed. Above all, I honor different and hybrid learning styles by offering choices and valuing diverse experiences.

Two principles I would like to see implemented as a student

There are two teaching practices and principles I would like to see implemented fully in my own courses as a student. The first is *encouraging active learning*. I would benefit from short, structured activities embedded throughout each module: small-cases tied to current modules, time-boxed team problem-solving with clearly designated roles, brief explain-to-a-peer segments and applied mini-projects that require transferring a concept into a realistic scenario. With clear

prompts, simple criteria, and tight pacing, these tasks stay manageable while still being meaningful. Instead of just moving from reading to note-taking, each session becomes a cycle of understanding, applying, and reflecting, a process that builds confidence one small success at a time.

The second is giving ***prompt feedback***. Having clear systems and predictable turnaround times would help keep the learning process on track. Early check-ins could highlight what students already know and where the gaps are, guiding instruction from the start. For bigger assignments, chances to submit drafts and revise would create real opportunities for growth. Knowing, for example, that feedback on short tasks would arrive within two or three days would make it easier to plan. Adding structured peer reviews could make the process even richer, since reviewing a classmate's work sharpens your own sense of quality before turning back to your own.

Conclusion

In summary, andragogy explains who adult learners are and what they need, while the seven principles show how to meet those needs in practice. Together they guide courses that respect prior experience, focus attention, and turn practice into real progress. By prioritizing active learning and timely feedback, I can strengthen my own learning while shaping instruction that helps others do the same. The result is a clearer link between theory and application, better use of time, and lasting impact.

References

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Class Notes, Videos and supplementary readings by Analisa McMillan, PhD, MEd, Instructor,
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